

FamilyNest

Build Timeline

Site quality review through gift purchase flow

Session window

April 23 — May 15, 2026

Scope

Eighteen pull requests across three weeks. Started as a real site-quality review of familynest.io. Ended with a buyer-to-recipient gift purchase flow live in production.

Strategic pivots

Audience explicitly narrowed to tight-knit nuclear families (parents + kids) — not extended/multi-generational. Gift-givers kept as a kept persona despite the pivot.

WHAT CHANGED

Executive summary

Public landing page

From a wall of features and three buttons saying different things to a phone-first hero, three lead features (Journal / Voice Memos / Time Capsules) with an opt-in expander for the rest, and a single consistent CTA — **Start Your Family Nest** — across the whole site.

Signed-in dashboard

Weekly Streak (off-brand: app sells itself as *not social media*) removed. The intrusive purple Quick Actions popover deleted. Four small competing widgets below 'In the Nest' collapsed into a single rotating **Serendipity Card**. Nav dropdowns now have grouped section headers so power-user families like Thompson can still scan quickly.

New user defaults

Default feature seed for new families trimmed from 10 add-ons to 3 (voice memos, family letters, traditions). Onboarding checklist now nudges *write-first* instead of *invite-others-first*. WelcomeModal no longer auto-opens and block the dashboard.

Gift purchase flow

Built from scratch over four PRs. Replaces the 'wrap your own login on a card' workaround with a real flow: buyer pays as guest → Stripe webhook persists a *pending_gifts* row → recipient gets an email → recipient sets their own password and owns a Legacy Nest from day one. Buyer also gets a *they opened your gift* notification.

Infrastructure

Two important truthing changes: CLAUDE.md updated to admit CI doesn't auto-apply migrations (it doesn't — a manual MCP step is required), and a billing/plan enforcement re-audit confirmed no new findings and no regressions since the previous audit.

The build, chronologically

Weeks 1–2 — Site quality review & simplification

PR #113 Landing simplification

- Phone-first hero mockup (mobile-first product).
- "See more features" expander: lead with 3, expand to 6.
- Unified primary CTA across the site.
- Removed duplicate *Family Media. Not Social Media.* pill.

PR #114 Dashboard simplification

- Killed the Weekly Streak widget (off-brand).
- Removed the intrusive purple Quick Actions popover.
- Relabeled left-edge music tab to *Playlist*.
- Cream placeholder background on photo tiles.

PR #116 Memories consolidation

- Removed One Line A Day entirely.
- Demoted Letters from core nav to opt-in catalog item.
- Backfill migration so existing families don't lose Letters.

PR #117 Hotfix: `journal_perspectives.author_id`

- Pre-existing 400 query (column is *family_member_id*).
- Silently failed for months; surfaced during deeper review.

PR #118 Hotfix: journal entry page crashed on every load

- Server component passing inline arrow function to client component.
- Fixed with `serverAction.bind(null, id)` pattern.

PR #119 **Nav reorg + pricing copy**

- Grouped section headers inside every dropdown.
- Items moved to honest homes (Time Capsules → Memories, etc.).
- Extras dropdown deleted; Feature Catalog moved to avatar menu.
- Full Nest pricing description rewritten.

PR #120 **Serendipity card**

- Four secondary home widgets collapsed into one rotating card.
- Day-seed picks Memory of the Day / On This Day / Gratitude / Inspiration.

PR #121 **Default-seed reduction**

- New families seeded with 3 features instead of 10.
- Existing families unaffected.

PR #122 **Onboarding tone + sequence**

- Inverted checklist order: **write first**, then photo, then invite.
- SerendipityCard tips rewritten in permission-granting tone.

PR #123 **WelcomeModal deferred**

- No longer auto-opens on first dashboard load.
- ■ Pick a theme link added to avatar menu instead.

PR #124 **ActivityFeed empty state polish**

- Aligned with the new onboarding flow tone.
- Added voice-memo CTA to match body copy.

PR #125 **Gift flow copy tighten**

- Step 3 credentials guidance made explicit.
- Removed misleading *Transfer ownership* bullet.
- ■ banner on `/login?mode=signup&plan=legacy_founding`.

Week 3 — Infrastructure & audits

PR #126 Migration workflow honesty

- CLAUDE.md corrected: CI does **not** auto-apply migrations.
- *scripts/check-pending-migrations.sh* guard added.
- Disabled CI workflow left in place (reconciliation is 4–6h project).

PR #127 Billing re-audit (2026-05-05)

- Re-audit covering changes since 2026-04-05.
- **Zero new findings, zero regressions.**
- Snapshot at *docs/BILLING_AUDIT_2026-05-05.md*.

Week 3 — Gift purchase flow

PR #128 Phase A — schema + design doc

- Migration: *pending_gifts* table (applied via Supabase MCP).
- *docs/GIFT_FLOW_DESIGN.md* with 6 open questions resolved.
- Refund policy locked in §7 of the design doc.

PR #129 Phase B — buyer flow

- */gift/buy* form (recipient → message → buyer fieldsets).
- */api/gift/checkout* Stripe session with gift metadata.
- */gift/sent* confirmation page.
- No auth required — buyer pays as a guest.

PR #130 Phase C — webhook + emails

- Gift branch at top of *checkout.session.completed*.
- Early-return so self-purchase flow is never touched.
- Idempotent on *stripe_session_id* unique constraint.
- Recipient + buyer emails via Resend.

PR #131 **Phase D — recipient redemption**

- */gift/claim/[token]* server-rendered page with 4 states.
- */api/gift/claim* creates auth user + family + applies plan.
- New-user and existing-user paths both supported.
- Buyer's *they opened your gift* email closes the loop.

What the gift flow delivers

A buyer fills */gift/buy*, pays via Stripe, recipient gets an email titled “[Buyer] gave you a Family Nest”, clicks the link, sets a password, and owns a Legacy Nest with 10 GB storage from day one. No login sharing. No mental gymnastics. No ownership transfer fine print.

Strategic choices locked this session

Audience: tight-knit nuclear families

Parents + kids. Not extended/multi-generational, not grandparent-gifters. This pivot shaped the default-seed reduction, the onboarding sequence, and the SerendipityCard copy. The pivot is captured in *memory/project_target_audience.md* for the next session to remember.

Gift-givers persona stays

Despite the nuclear-family pivot, the user explicitly kept the gift-givers persona on the landing page. The full gift purchase flow is a direct consequence of that decision.

Pricing tiers stay as-is

Free / Full Nest \$6.99 monthly / Legacy \$249–\$349 one-time. When offered the option to drop the middle tier, the user declined. The Full Nest description was rewritten to differentiate clearly.

Refund policy

"Gifts are refundable any time before the recipient redeems them. After redemption, all sales are final."
Manual via Stripe dashboard for v1 — no self-serve refund UI. Policy surfaced on the */gift/buy* form.

Migration workflow: MCP, not CI

CI workflow is intentionally disabled. Apply migrations via Supabase MCP *apply_migration* before merging any PR with new SQL files. Reconciling the existing version drift is a 4–6 hour cleanup with real risk — not worth doing without a clear plan.

STILL OPEN

Outstanding & parked

■ Real-money production gift-flow test

The gift flow is shipped and live but has not yet been exercised with real Stripe + real Resend emails. A walkthrough exists in chat (6 steps: visit /gift, pay \$249, verify 3 emails, redeem, verify buyer-opened email, refund self via Stripe dashboard). This is the **top priority** for whoever picks this up next.

Phase E polish — partially done

- ■ GiftWelcomeBanner on the dashboard for *?welcome=gift* — already in the repo.
- ■ Printable gift card view (with print-specific CSS) — not built.
- ■ "View your sent gifts" page for buyers — never started, low priority.

Other backlog (priority order)

- Onboarding flow audit — partial wins shipped; still room.
- Performance pass — /speed-review skill exists, never run.
- /blog and /contact page audits — never looked.
- KPI/analytics for the UX changes shipped this session.
- G7 (long-standing) — client-side upload pre-gating in 5 modules.
- Re-enable CI migration workflow — 4–6 hour reconciliation.

Cold-start guide for the next session

Read *docs/SESSION_HANDOFF.md* first — it's the canonical single page that captures everything in this PDF plus the specific gotchas that bit us. The PDF is for human storytelling; the markdown is for the model.

Then open with: “Did the real-money gift flow test happen? If yes — what worked, what didn't? If no — let me know if you want to walk through it, or pick from the parked backlog above.”

Files to know about

docs/SESSION_HANDOFF.md — cold-start handoff doc.

docs/GIFT_FLOW_DESIGN.md — gift flow architecture.

docs/BILLING_FINDINGS.md — canonical billing audit log.

docs/BILLING_AUDIT_2026-05-05.md — most recent audit snapshot.

scripts/check-pending-migrations.sh — pre-merge SQL guard.

memory/project_target_audience.md — audience pivot note.

CLAUDE.md — Database Migrations section has the canonical workflow.